

Master Vista's Control Panel

Understanding the Control Panel is the secret to managing Vista. Here are our top tips

The Control Panel is home to many of Windows' advanced system configuration options such as display, sound and security settings.

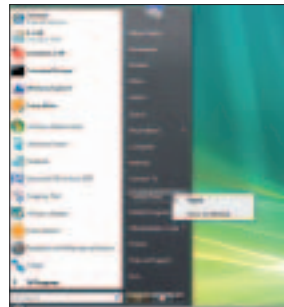
It has been with us for many years and hasn't really changed much in appearance during that time, despite the addition of several functions.

However, in Windows Vista, Microsoft has radically altered the Control Panel's look and feel, which can create confusion among users, even for those who are more experienced.

In this section, we will give you a guided tour around the new interface, show you some of the most useful new features and help you discover some of the lesser-known but very useful functions within Vista's Control Panel, such as keyboard shortcuts and Autoplay.

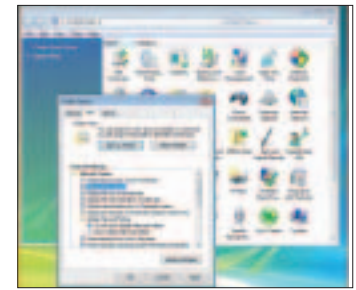
Tip 1

Vista offers several ways to open the Control Panel. The easiest is to double-click the icon in the Welcome Center, which runs when Vista starts up. Another way is to press the Start button and choose Control Panel from the list on the right-hand panel of the Start menu. You'll also find a link to the Control Panel in the task ribbon of your Computer window (Start > Computer). If you'd like a quick-access icon to the Control Panel on your desktop, simply right-click where it says Control Panel in the Start menu and choose Show on Desktop as shown in the picture (right). Another way of running the Control Panel is to type control panel in the Search box on the Start menu and then hit the Enter key.



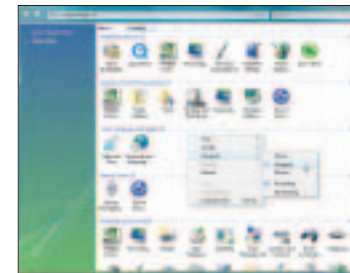
Tip 2

Now you've opened up the Control Panel, you might not like the way it looks, as in Vista all the tasks are arranged by category. It's easy to make it look like XP's version by clicking the Classic View link in the left-hand panel. To return to the Vista-type view, click the Control Panel Home link in the left-hand pane, or just click the Back arrow at the top left of the window next to the address bar. If you miss the old-style menu bar (whether in the Control Panel or any other Explorer window), you can toggle it on and off by pressing the Alt key on your keyboard. From here, you can make the menu bar permanently visible by choosing Tools > Folder Options, then clicking on the View tab as shown in the screenshot (left).



Tip 3

The default Classic View of the Control Panel is useful but still not perfect. You get to see an icon for every applet, but they're only sorted by name, making it hard to pick out what you need. It's easy



to organise this view, though — just right-click an empty part of the window and select Group By > Category. You'll still see an icon for every applet, but this time they're displayed in categories. Another irritation with the regular icon view is that long applet names are only partially displayed ('Problem Reports and Solutions' becomes 'Problem Reports a...', for instance). Display the applets as tiles (right-click in the window, select View > Tiles) to always see the full name.

Tip 4

If your choice of Control Panel layout doesn't help you find the function you need then Windows search should be able to help. Click in the search box at the top-right of the window, then type a word or two that relates to the feature you're looking for: disk,